

Stats 21 Course Syllabus

Python and Other Technologies for Data Science — Fall 2026

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Course Information

Summary

This class covers the use of Python and other technologies for data analysis and data science. The course will focus on programming with Python and a selection of its libraries: NumPy, pandas, and matplotlib for the purpose of data processing, data cleaning, data analysis, and machine learning. Other technologies covered will include Jupyter notebook and Git. Intended for Data Theory majors as an introduction to the Python language and libraries most frequently used in data science.

Learning Outcomes

Upon completion of this course, students will be able to:

- Create reproducible Jupyter notebooks and manage their work in a GitHub repository.
- Read, write, and explain intermediate Python code.
- Translate a question into a computational task by identifying the required inputs, expected outputs, and relevant assumptions.
- Test code using representative examples and edge cases, investigate unexpected results, and explain why a solution works.
- Import, clean, reshape, and summarize data for exploratory data analysis.
- Create and interpret data visualizations in the context of the question and the data.
- Evaluate suggestions from documentation, other people, and AI tools using their own understanding, tests, and knowledge of the problem.

Prerequisites

Stats 20

Lecture Times

- Mondays, Wednesdays, Fridays 10AM - 10:50AM
- Geology Building 3656
- Lectures will be recorded

Office Hours Schedule

- Mondays 11:00 AM - 11:50 AM (in-person)
- Mondays 4:30 PM - 5:15 PM (online)
- Tuesdays 4:30 PM - 5:15 PM (online)
- Wednesdays 11:00 AM - 11:50 AM (in-person)
- Wednesdays 1:40 PM - 2:30 PM (online)
- Thursdays 4:30 PM - 5:15 PM (online)
- Zoom link for online office hours:
 - <https://ucla.zoom.us/j/98887074323?pwd=bjFqd2ZCNnRqQmMvU3dnYkVad0RqQT09>
 - Meeting ID: 988 8707 4323
 - Passcode: 916280
 - Please **turn on your cameras**
- Physical Office Location: Math Sciences Building 8105 J (8th floor)
- Also general office hours (open to students in any class and to former students):
- Saturdays 10AM - 11AM
 - <https://ucla.zoom.us/j/96806536111>
 - Meeting ID: 968 0653 6111
 - Passcode: 023194
 - Note: Office hours on Saturday use a different Zoom link.

Special Dates

Dates are subject to changes and updates. The professor will make an announcement on Canvas/BruinLearn with any changes not listed here.

Fall Quarter Dates

- First lecture for this course: Fri Sep 25, 2026
- Instruction ends: Fri Dec 4, 2026
- Final exam for this course: Tue Dec 8, 2026, 8:00 AM - 11:00 AM

University dates follow the [UCLA academic calendar](#).

Dates with No Office Hours

- No office hours on the following dates:
 - Wed Nov 11 - Veterans Day Holiday
 - Thu Nov 26 - Thanksgiving Holiday
- No office hours during Finals Week (Dec 7-11).
- Last office hours for the quarter: Sat Dec 5 10AM
- Additional office hours cancellations will be announced on Canvas/BruinLearn.

Online Lecture

- Wed Nov 25 - The lecture before Thanksgiving will be held online. There will be no in-person class meeting.

Dates with No Class

- Wed Nov 11 - Veterans Day Holiday
- Thu Nov 26 - Fri Nov 27 - Thanksgiving Holiday

Outline of topics

- 1) Week 1: Git, GitHub, Jupyter
- 2) Week 2: Python Basics: variables, expressions, statements
- 3) Week 3: Python Functions: encapsulation, recursion, return values, iteration
- 4) Week 4: Python Data types: strings, lists, dictionaries, tuples
- 5) Week 5: Python OOP: Classes and objects, methods, inheritance
- 6) Week 6: Pythonic code: List comprehensions, kwargs; Numpy
- 7) Week 7: Pandas: Importing, reshaping, and cleaning data
- 8) Week 8: Pandas: Wrangling, and Aggregation
- 9) Week 9: Data Visualization
- 10) Week 10: Miscellaneous topics

Websites

Announcements and assignments will be posted via Canvas / Bruin Learn <https://bruinlearn.ucla.edu>
Notes will be uploaded to GitHub Repository: <https://github.com/smileschen/26-fall-stats-21>

Regular homework assignments will be submitted via Gradescope. Students will be invited and will need to create an account. <https://www.gradescope.com>

DataCamp certificates of completion will be submitted to the corresponding assignments in Canvas/Bruin Learn.

Software

Students will need to install git: <https://git-scm.com/downloads>

In this course, we will use Python

Books

Think Python, 3rd Edition

- By: Allen B. Downey
- Publisher: Green Tea Press and O'Reilly Media, Inc.

The textbook is available free to all at the publisher's website: <https://greenteapress.com/wp/think-python-3rd-edition/>

The print version is also available for purchase at any retailer of your choice. If you decide to purchase the text, you must get the third edition.

This is an excellent text that emphasizes brevity. Please be sure to do your reading. Every sentence is valuable.

Python Data Science Handbook, 2nd Edition

- By: Jake VanderPlas
- Publisher: O'Reilly Media, Inc.

UCLA students can read the textbook in their web browser at the following site:

<https://learning.oreilly.com/library/view/python-data-science/9781098121211/?ar>

Select "University of California, Los Angeles" and choose "Sign In with my Institution"

The print version is also available for purchase at any retailer of your choice.

Grading Policies

Grade Breakdown

- 15% Lecture Participation
- 20% DataCamp Homework
- 20% Homework Assignments
- 45% Final Exam

Letter Grade cutoffs

Letter grades are assigned on a straight scale as follows:

- 59.9 and below: F
- 60.0 - 69.9: D
- 70.0 - 76.9: C, 77.0 - 79.9: C+
- 80.0 - 82.9: B-, 83.0 - 86.9: B, 87.0 - 89.9: B+
- 90.0 - 92.9: A-, 93.0 and up A, top 5% of students: A+

I do not curve grades. I do not assign C-, D+ or D-. The top 5% of students will get an A+. An A+ is the only grade assignment that is assigned based on performance relative to peers.

If you are a Stats major or minor it is important that you take the class for letter grade. Taking the grade as pass/no-pass will not fulfill the requirements for completing the major or minor.

Lecture Participation

Lecture participation is worth **15% of the course grade**. We will use **iClicker** for two short questions about the course material during each lecture. The two questions together constitute one lecture participation quiz.

Getting Started with iClicker

iClicker is provided by UCLA at no cost to students. You may respond using the iClicker Student mobile app or the web app on a laptop; you do not need to purchase a physical clicker.

1. Follow the student account instructions on [UCLA's iClicker page](#). Sign in through UCLA's campus portal using your UCLA Logon credentials, and create or link your iClicker account as directed.
2. Confirm that the Fall 2026 Stats 21 course appears in your iClicker course list after the Bruin Learn roster is synchronized. Follow any additional enrollment instructions posted on Bruin Learn. If the course does not appear, resolve the account or enrollment issue before graded polling begins.
3. Bring a charged phone, tablet, or laptop with internet access to lecture. Open iClicker, select our course, and join the active class session.
4. Submit your own answer while each poll is open and check that your response has been recorded. Review your participation scores in Bruin Learn regularly.

Participation Credit

Each lecture quiz is worth **2 points: 1 point for responding to each question, regardless of whether the answer is correct**. Answering both questions earns full credit; answering one earns half credit; answering neither earns zero. Each lecture carries the same weight.

You must attend the lecture in person and submit your own responses during class. For the scheduled online lecture on **Wednesday, November 25**, you must attend online and respond during the live lecture. Polls close during class. Watching a recording afterward does not earn participation credit.

Answer independently unless the instructor explicitly invites discussion. Submitting responses for another student, having someone respond for you, or responding remotely to an in-person lecture is academic dishonesty. Do not use AI or other people to supply your individual responses.

Missed Quizzes

I will automatically drop your **three lowest lecture participation quiz scores**, including zeros for missed lectures, with **no questions asked and no documentation required**. Each drop applies to one full lecture's quiz, not to one individual question.

These three drops are intended to cover illness, emergencies, and other unavoidable absences. They also cover missed polls, lateness, forgotten devices, and individual technical problems. Do not treat the drops as additional absences to use in advance of an emergency.

There are no make-up quizzes, late submissions, alternative participation assignments, or additional discretionary drops. Once the three lowest scores have been dropped, all remaining lecture quiz scores count toward your participation grade. Please do not request an additional drop or a make-up for an absence or missed poll. This policy does not change approved accommodations described in the Accommodations for Students with Disabilities section.

If a class-wide iClicker outage or an instructor error affects a lecture quiz, the instructor will remove that quiz from the participation grade for all students. A removed quiz does not count against students and does not use one of their three drops.

Regular Homework

Each regular homework assignment is worth the same amount and will be scored out of 100 points. None of the regular homework scores will be dropped. Unless otherwise announced, regular homework is due at **6:00 PM on the listed due date**, local time in Los Angeles. It is your responsibility to verify that your assignment successfully uploaded by the deadline. The submission, late-work, extension, and regrade policies in this section apply to regular homework; DataCamp has separate requirements below.

All homework assignments will be posted as an ipynb file. You will download the ipynb file and modify it with your answers.

After entering all of your answers, select “Kernel” > “Restart and Run All”. Check to make sure all requested answers are clearly visible.

Then students will submit the PDF file to Gradescope. Do not submit the ipynb file.

Homework submission requirements

- Unless instructed otherwise, homework **must be a PDF with letter-sized pages**.
- When submitting homework to Gradescope, the **pages of the submission must be properly assigned to/tagged with the corresponding question**.
 - When assigning pages, make sure ALL of the corresponding output for a particular question is assigned to the question. You can tag multiple pages to a single question. A single page can be tagged to multiple questions.
 - For the purposes of determining if a submission is late or not, Gradescope uses the time of the upload as the submission time. You can take additional time to assign/tag the pages and your submission time will not be affected.
 - If the output is not correctly assigned to/tagged with the question, it will be graded as if the output is missing. Regrade requests due to incorrect assignment or tagging of output will not be considered.

- Output for each homework question must be clearly visible to receive credit.
 - Graders do not have the luxury of trying to run your code or debug your code. They may not even have time to see what your individual lines of code can do.
 - The graders will look for the printed results, so it is **very important** you properly print the requested results in your document. It is your job to make sure that you get the credit you deserve.
- It is very important you review your own output before submitting. Sometimes a small edit in one section will cause other sections (that used to work with no issues) to suddenly break. We cannot give you credit for output that results in errors. **Be sure to review all pages of your output before submitting.**

Example of bad submission:

Problem 1: Use a loop to produce a list of the first 10 numbers in the Fibonacci sequence

```
x = [1, 1]
for i in range(1, 9):
    x.append(x[i-1] + x[i])
```

The grader has no idea what was produced. You will receive 0 points for this submission.

Example of good submission:

Problem 1: Use a loop to produce a list of the first 10 numbers in the Fibonacci sequence

```
x = [1, 1]
for i in range(1, 9):
    x.append(x[i-1] + x[i])
print(x)

[1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, 34, 55]
```

This is the exact same code, but adds the line `print(x)`. This small change makes a big difference.

It is your responsibility to read through the rendered output and to make sure that every problem and task has the required output before submitting your assignment.

Late Policy for Regular Homework

Homework deadlines are based on local time in Los Angeles, California.

There is a 10 minute grace period for homework submissions. Submissions up to 10 minutes and 59 seconds late will be accepted with no penalty.

Homework assignments submitted 11 minutes late or more will be accepted with penalty. There is a deduction of 5 points for being less than one hour late. An additional 5-point deduction will be taken for each additional hour it is late.

Deductions are suspended between the hours of 12 am and 5:59 pm the following day. The penalties resume at 6 pm.

The maximum late penalty is 60 points.

So if an assignment is due at 6pm, a homework assignment submitted on Gradescope at

- 6:10:59 pm will receive no penalty.
- 6:11:00 pm will receive 5-point penalty.
- 6:59:59 pm will receive 5-point penalty.
- 7:00:00 pm will receive 10-point penalty.
- 7:59:59 pm will receive 10-point penalty.
- 8:00:00 pm will receive 15-point penalty.
- 11:59:59 pm will receive 30-point penalty.
- 12:00:01 am (following day) will receive 30-point penalty.
- 5:59:59 pm (following day) will receive 30-point penalty.
- 6:00:00 pm (following day) will receive 35-point penalty.
- 10:59:59 pm (following day) will receive 55-point penalty.
- 11:00:00 pm (following day) will receive 60-point penalty.
- Anything later (but less than 7 days late) will be accepted with a 60-point penalty.

I strongly advise uploading the homework to Gradescope well in advance of the deadline in case there are connectivity problems or server issues.

After 7 calendar days, late homework assignments will not be accepted. Exceptions beyond the 7-day submission window will be granted in only extreme circumstances and will only be granted via an office hours meeting (Zoom or in-person) with the professor.

Regular Homework Extensions

I generally grant a 72-hour extension for regular homework if you contact me in office hours to request it before the homework deadline. Extension requests made via email will be ignored.

An approved extension establishes a new deadline **72 hours after the original deadline**. The grace period, late penalties, and seven-day submission window are measured from the new deadline. No late penalty applies before the extended deadline.

Requests for extensions after the homework deadline will be granted only in extreme situations.

Homework Regrades

Homework assignments are graded by TAs. Occasionally the grader may make a mistake in grading your submission.

Both the TA and the professor have the authority to change the grade of a homework assignment.

All requests for regrading a homework assignment must be submitted via Gradescope.

Do not email the TA or the professor for a request to regrade an assignment.

Please only submit a regrade request if you are certain that a mistake was made in the grading of your homework.

During a regrade request, the TA or Professor may discover and deduct points for mistakes that were not found during the initial grading. It is possible your regrade request results in a lower grade for the assignment.

DataCamp Homework

DataCamp invitations provide free access for 6 months and go to your myUCLA email address. Check the **To** field and use that **exact address**; @ucla.edu and @g.ucla.edu are distinct, even with forwarding. Accept the invitation to join **2026 Fall Stats 21** using an existing account with the invited address. If your account uses a different address, log out and create a new account with the invited address through the invitation to access course materials.

Your DataCamp first and last name must match Canvas. There are **six DataCamp assignments**, each consisting of one assigned course. All six have equal weight within the DataCamp category, which is worth 20% of the course grade.

Submission and Grading

Complete the assigned DataCamp course and submit its **certificate of completion to the corresponding Canvas/Bruin Learn assignment**. Each assignment is worth 100 points before any late deduction. Credit requires the certificate of completion; completing the course on DataCamp alone does not submit the assignment.

Unless otherwise announced, DataCamp certificates are due at **11:59 PM on the listed due date**, local time in Los Angeles. Lateness is determined by the certificate's submission time in Canvas/Bruin Learn.

Late Policy for DataCamp

There is a 10-minute grace period: certificates submitted up to 10 minutes and 59 seconds late receive no penalty. After that grace period, the following deductions apply to the assignment's 100 points:

Certificate submission time	Deduction
After the grace period but less than 24 hours late	10 points
At least 24 hours but less than 72 hours late	20 points
At least 72 hours and up to 7 days late	30 points
More than 7 days late, by the final submission cutoff below	60 points

Only one deduction applies; the penalties are not cumulative. **All DataCamp certificates must be submitted by 11:59 PM on Friday, December 4, 2026.** Certificates submitted after this final cutoff will not be accepted. The grace period does not extend this final cutoff. Missing certificates receive zero credit.

Tentative Homework Deadlines

Homework deadlines are subject to change. Any changes will be announced on Canvas/Bruin Learn. All times are local time in Los Angeles.

Regular Homework (6:00 PM)

- HW1: Fri October 9, 2026
- HW2: Wed October 21, 2026
- HW3: Wed November 4, 2026
- HW4: Fri November 20, 2026
- HW5: Wed December 2, 2026

DataCamp Homework (11:59 PM)

- Intro to Shell: Fri October 2, 2026
- Intro to Git: Wed October 7, 2026
- Intro to Python: Mon October 12, 2026
- Intermediate Python: Mon October 19, 2026
- Data Manipulation with Pandas: Mon October 26, 2026
- Joining Data with Pandas: Mon November 2, 2026

Final Exam

There will be an **in-person, paper final exam** covering programming concepts in Python. Further details, including permitted materials, will be provided to the class.

The final exam is scheduled for **Tuesday, December 8, 2026, 8:00 AM - 11:00 AM** (Los Angeles time). See the [UCLA Schedule of Classes](#) for the exam location and any updates.

Final Exam Make-up Policy

If you know in advance that you will be unavailable for the final exam, contact me before the exam to explain the situation and discuss an alternative arrangement.

If you are ill on the day of the exam, stay home and do not attend the exam. If illness or another emergency prevents you from taking the exam, contact me within **24 hours of the scheduled exam** to arrange a make-up. An office hours visit is not required.

Other emergent situations for missing the exam will require documentation.

If a make-up cannot be scheduled, eligible students will be assigned an **Incomplete (I)** and will take the final exam during **Winter Quarter 2027**, with arrangements made directly with the instructor. Under [UCLA's Incomplete policy](#), an Incomplete requires work of passing quality that remains unfinished for good cause, such as illness or another serious problem.

Course Grade Changes

Final course grades are governed by [UCLA Academic Senate Regulation 313](#). Grades other than DR, I, and IP are final when filed, but may be corrected for clerical or procedural errors through the university's grade-change process. The university also provides a grading grievance process for grades assigned on grounds other than academic performance.

Please report a suspected error promptly so that it can be reviewed. There is no course-imposed one-quarter cutoff for correcting an eligible error. Requests made more than one year after the original filing require

additional department-chair verification under UCLA policy. A final grade cannot be raised by retaking an examination or submitting additional work, except through the applicable I or IP completion process.

Other Course Policies

Some of the following verbiage has been taken and adapted from the CEILS Syllabus Template as well as various campus resource websites.

Copyright Policy

All course materials posted on the course website or distributed in class (including but not limited to lecture slides, homework assignments, lecture videos, quizzes, exams) are intended for personal use only by students enrolled in this course. **It is a violation of course policy to post, share, or distribute any course material electronically or physically without permission from the instructor, even after the course is over.**

Policies on Academic Integrity

As a student and member of the University community, you are here to get an education and are, therefore, expected to demonstrate integrity in your academic endeavors. All students must uphold University of California Standards of Student Conduct as administered by the Office of the Dean of Students. Students are subject to disciplinary action for several types of misconduct, including but not limited to: cheating, multiple submissions, plagiarism, prohibited collaboration, facilitating academic dishonesty, or knowingly furnishing false information.

In addition, each student is the sole owner of their own code and work and must NOT do any of the following:

- Submit work that was written by someone other than the student.
- Use an AI tool to produce homework solutions in place of their own work, as explained below.
- Post the course questions on forums other than the designated course discussion forum.
- Submit someone else's work or a modification of that work, with or without that person's knowledge.
- Allow someone else to submit their work or a modification of their work.
- Contract course work out to others.
- Plan or execute with another student(s) some form of cheating during an exam.
- Make use of unauthorized material during an exam or for preparation of an exam.
- View completed assignments or exams from the current or previous iterations of the course, regardless of their source.

Often, a student who considers cheating feels unprepared and under pressure. If you are at a point where you are contemplating cheating, please come talk to me instead.

For more information, see UCLA's [Student Conduct Office](#) and [current Student Conduct Code](#).

Using AI to Support Learning

You may use AI tools, including ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot, Gemini, and Claude, for **hints, explanations, help finding relevant functions, and debugging code you have written**. Asking what an error message means, how a function works, or why your code produces an unexpected result is permitted. Targeted suggestions for correcting your own code are also permitted.

You must do the thinking yourself: choose your approach, develop and test your answer, and be able to explain the code and results you submit. Evaluate AI suggestions instead of accepting them without understanding them.

Do not paste a homework prompt or individual question into an AI tool and ask it to write the solution. Do not use a series of requests to have AI build the solution for you, or copy an AI-generated solution and present it as your own. You may describe the specific difficulty you are working through and share relevant portions of your own code to ask for a hint, explanation, or debugging help.

These permissions apply to learning and homework assistance. **AI may not be used to answer iClicker questions or during exams unless the instructor explicitly permits it.**

Sexual Harassment, Sexual Violence, and Gender Discrimination

UCLA prohibits sexual violence, sexual harassment, discrimination, and retaliation. If you or someone you know has experienced this conduct, support and reporting resources are available.

Confidential advocacy: UCLA CARE supports students affected by sexual or gender-based violence. CARE is located at **205 Covell Commons, 330 De Neve Drive**. Call **(310) 206-2465**, email advocate@careprogram.ucla.edu, or [request a CARE appointment](#). Current hours and contact information are on the [CARE website](#).

Reporting: UCLA's Civil Rights Office (CRO) receives reports of sexual misconduct, discrimination, harassment, and retaliation. Contact CRO at **Murphy Hall, Suite 2255, (310) 825-7102**, or civilrights@ucla.edu. See [CRO reporting and support information](#) and [current contact information](#). CRO is a reporting office, not a confidential advocacy service.

Your instructor and TAs are Responsible Employees under UC policy. When we learn in our teaching roles that a student may have experienced sexual violence or sexual harassment, we must report that information to CRO. See UCLA's [faculty and staff reporting responsibilities](#). For confidential support, contact CARE or Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS).

Mental Health and Student Well-Being

Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) is here to support your mental health needs as you pursue your academic goals.

All registered UCLA students are eligible for same-day clinical consultation and help with referrals, linkage, treatment recommendations, and coordination of mental health care and support regardless of insurance plan or current residence.

CAPS provides 24/7 crisis counseling by phone at (310) 825-0768. For urgent mental health concerns, call rather than email. In a life-threatening emergency, call 911.

[CAPS services](#) and [contact information](#).

Attending and completing university coursework is difficult and can become burdensome both physically and psychologically. Take care of your mental well-being and seek support from some of the many excellent resources offered at CAPS.

It's every Bruin's responsibility to refer or reach out on behalf of students who are in distress or might harm themselves or others. If you are concerned about another student or member of the campus, please consider consulting with a professional.

<https://counseling.ucla.edu/concerned-about-a-bruin/concerned-about-a-bruin>

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

Students requesting disability-related accommodations should contact the **Center for Accessible Education (CAE)** as soon as possible at **(310) 825-1501**, **A255 Murphy Hall**, or caeintake@saonet.ucla.edu. CAE determines reasonable accommodations and communicates approved accommodations to instructors.

Use **myCAE**, available through the [CAE website](#), to request accommodations and arrange for your accommodation letter to be shared with the instructor. Coordinate approved exam arrangements in advance and follow CAE's current scheduling deadlines. Contacting CAE early helps provide time to arrange accommodations.

See [CAE contact information](#) and the [CAE website](#) for current procedures and deadlines.

General Syllabus Policy

The instructor reserves the right to make changes to the syllabus. All changes to the syllabus will be announced to the class.

If any policy in the syllabus requires interpretation, the instructor will clarify the policy and the instructor's interpretation of the policy is final.

Additional Information

Undergraduate Mentoring

I am a mentor for undergraduates for the UCLA Department of Statistics. This means that you may visit me during office hours (or by appointment) for an informal meeting where you can ask questions unrelated to course content, such as research opportunities, graduate studies, career paths, or any other topic pertinent to your education. You are welcome to visit and meet even after the course ends.

Requests for Letters of Recommendation

If you think you might request a letter of recommendation in the future, please make an effort to make yourself known to me. I am not able to write strong letters of recommendation for students I do not know well.

I also do not have a good memory, so please visit office hours frequently and repeatedly introduce yourself to me. Please attend class in person and sit near the front of the classroom where I will see and recognize your face. Actively participate in class.

For a full guideline, please see this page on my personal website: <https://smileschen.com/lor.html>

Syllabus Copyright

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